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Chapter 2: Viewing the Clock Room Across Millennia of Philosophical History—A Comparison of Eastern and Western Approaches to the Mapping Gap

Abstract

This chapter is the second in the "Clock Room" series. Chapter 1 established the thought experiment and the fiber framework, advanced the analysis of three layers of irreversibility, and gave formal arguments for the irreversibility of the boundary case of a completely unknown mapping and for irreversibility under dimension reduction. This chapter situates this predicament—readings alone cannot guarantee their alignment with the real; when a task requires recovering state dimensions discarded by dimension reduction, this distance is ineliminable—within two and a half millennia of philosophical history. This predicament is not a new discovery, but a terrain that human beings have repeatedly arrived at across different eras.

This chapter traces two historical paths for handling this distance. The mainstream of Western metaphysics acknowledges the existence of the distance, and then attempts to bridge it with conceptual architectures—from Plato's Forms to Descartes' God, from Kant's transcendental categories to Hegel's dialectics. Each generation builds bridges more sophisticated than the last, but each bridge is itself a new mapping.

In certain Eastern lines of thought, this distance was never treated as a problem to be "handled" in the first place. This chapter selects four nodes—Laozi, the Diamond Sutra, the Sixth Patriarch Huineng, and Lu Jiuyuan and

Wang Yangming—letting them speak in their own languages. They are not saying the same thing, but they point toward a common zone: the problem is not that the mapping is insufficiently good, but that human beings have forgotten how they entered into the mapping in the first place.

The two paths undergo an unexpected convergence in modern times. Marx, setting out from the heartland of the Western tradition, independently arrived at a zone recognizable to certain Eastern lines of thought. The two paths differ in their points of departure, routes of travel, and the landscapes seen upon arrival, but both point in the same direction: not building better mapping systems, but returning to existence itself—returning to a mode of doing work that is sensuous, embodied, relational, and in direct contact with the world.

The method of this chapter is structural comparative reading—within the problem-domain of "how the distance between mapping and the real is handled," selecting several nodes of thought and capturing the recognizable structural relations between them and the argument of Chapter 1, rather than providing complete exegetical interpretations of classical texts. This chapter does not claim that these traditions are saying the same thing. It only marks a zone of mutual recognizability, presenting how paths setting out from different points of departure undergo structural adjacency in this zone, and what inspiration this adjacency holds for understanding the argument of Chapter 1.

Keywords

mapping gap; metaphysics; Tao Te Ching; Diamond Sutra; Inquiry on the Great Learning; alienation; subject-object dichotomy; time dimension; clock dimension

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§1 Two Paths for the Mapping Gap (The Distance / Interval Between Readings and the Real That Readings Alone Cannot Eliminate)

The incremental contribution of this book is the formalization and argumentation of the three layers of irreversibility—formal arguments for the boundary case of the completely unknown mapping and for irreversibility under dimension reduction, and a mechanism analysis of dynamic corrosion. But this interval itself—the distance between readings and the real that readings alone cannot eliminate—is not this book's discovery. Chapter 1 further argues that this distance is ineliminable when a task requires recovering the state dimensions discarded by dimension reduction. This chapter names it the "mapping gap" as an operational object of analysis.

There are two primary paths for handling this problem. They set out at roughly the same time, about two and a half thousand years ago, and traveled in entirely different directions.

The mainstream of Western metaphysics acknowledges the distance, and then builds bridges. This shore is the knower, the other shore is the real; Plato uses the Forms, Descartes uses God, Kant uses the transcendental categories, Hegel uses dialectics—all four are building bridges (the objectives and materials of each bridge differ; see the respective subsections of §2 for details). Each generation builds more sophisticated bridges than the last.

Let me clarify one thing first. "Bridge" and the "clock" of Chapter 1 are not on the same level—a clock is the reading-generating apparatus itself; a bridge is that class of effort that attempts to do something about the

distance between the reading and the real (either trying to cross over it, or establishing order within the distance, or declaring the distance dissolved). Plato, Descartes, Kant, and Hegel were doing the kind of thing that bridges do, not building new clocks.

That is just about intent. To speak of structure is different. Viewed from the geometry of Chapter 1, not one of these bridges truly reached the other shore. The finished product of each bridge is one more layer of readings added on this shore—a new clock face. The four philosophers themselves did not see it this way—Plato and Descartes saw themselves building bridges leading to the real; Kant did not see a bridge but order within this shore; Hegel saw that the very separation of the two shores ought to be sublated. Yet viewed from within the Clock Room, none of what they built ever left this shore.

What follows in this chapter uses "bridge-building" to narrate this path—adopting their own language. At the end of each subsection, a translation will be performed, clarifying what shape that bridge takes when placed within the geometry of this book.

In certain Eastern lines of thought, the interval between mapping and the real was not posited as a problem needing to be "handled." In their respective texts, this often manifests in different ways: "the real" was not presupposed as an entity independent of the cognitive process—if the "two shores" were never treated as independent from the outset, then the concept of a "bridge" also ceases to apply. The specific formulations of these texts are reserved for presentation in §3; only a principled summary is given here.

This summary is tendential, not a strict classification: within the Western tradition itself, there exist voices questioning the bridge (skepticism, the later Wittgenstein, Heidegger), and within the Eastern tradition, there is also a vast body of bridge-building work (Zhu Xi's investigation of things, Buddhist logic). This chapter focuses on the structural difference between the two dominant orientations and does not claim to provide a complete description of the two great traditions. The remaining methodological qualifications—the representativeness of the selected nodes, the operationality of the structural reading, the asymmetry of translation—are uniformly

moved to a footnote[1].

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§2 The Western Path: Building Better Clocks

§2.1 Plato: An Early Systematic Treatment of the Problem of Shadows

Plato's (c. 428–348 BCE) allegory of the cave and the Clock Room thought experiment share a structurally comparable feature—both describe a situation where knowers are confined within a specific mapping, unable to directly contact the real. Yet the two are independently constructed, and their argumentative directions also differ: Plato's allegory leads to the Theory of Forms—the real lies on the other shore, and reason can bring people there; the Clock Room leads to a proof of the irreversibility of mapping—in the boundary case of a completely unknown mapping, even with an infinite number of readings, the fiber is not a single point. What follows extracts only one facet of Plato's philosophy directly relevant to the mapping predicament for a structural reading; Plato's Theory of Forms has another facet—the Forms are not merely beyond the sensible world, but are the true being within the world—which this chapter does not unfold.

In Book VII of the *Republic* (514a–521b), Socrates describes the following scene: a group of people have been

[1]The structural comparative reading of this chapter contains several methodological qualifications, collected here for concentrated explanation, to avoid repeated interruption in the main text:

(1) **The operationality of node selection**: The philosophers and classical texts appearing in this chapter are not used as authoritative grounds for argument, but as instances of different strategies for handling the problem of "the distance between mapping and the real." Their correctness does not derive from their names, but from the recognizable structural relations between the structures of their strategies and the argument of Chapter 1. The use of classical texts in this chapter is operational—capturing only one or several facets directly relevant to the problem-domain of the "mapping gap"; it is not an authoritative interpretation of the original texts in the exegetical sense, nor does it claim to exhaust the entire content of the selected thinkers. The ontological facet of Plato's Theory of Forms, the full structure of Kant's transcendental deduction, the concrete unfolding of Hegelian dialectics in the *Phenomenology of Spirit*, the relationship of Huineng's thought to Indian dhyāna, the similarities and differences between Wang Yangming and Lu Xiangshan—these all lie beyond the range of this chapter.

(2) **The representativeness and non-representativeness of node selection**: This chapter selects Plato–Descartes–Kant–Hegel–Heidegger in the West, and Laozi–the Diamond Sutra–Huineng–Lu Jiuyuan and Wang Yangming in the East. This selection is tendential, not a complete map of the two great traditions: within the Western tradition, there exist voices questioning the bridge (skepticism, the later Wittgenstein, Heidegger himself); within the Eastern tradition, there is also a vast body of bridge-building work (Zhu Xi's investigation of things, Buddhist logic, Mohist dialectics). This chapter focuses on the structural difference between the two dominant orientations, not on a complete description of the two great traditions; the selected nodes do not represent "the only correct representatives," only a clear facet of that path within its problem-domain.

(3) **The asymmetry of translation**: This chapter's use of Western nodes and its use of Eastern nodes are not entirely symmetrical. For Western nodes, this chapter uses the mathematical language of Chapter 1 to read their argumentative structures; this is a "re-reading" within the Western epistemological tradition—the two share the basic architecture of the "subject-object dichotomy." For Eastern nodes, this chapter is using the language of Chapter 1 to translate a set of texts that do not share its point of departure—Laozi, Huineng, and Wang Yangming did not take "mapping" or "fiber" as their concerns. This act of translation is itself what Laozi criticized ("the Dao that can be described in language is not the constant Dao"). This chapter's way of handling this asymmetry is: on the one hand, acknowledging that the translation is not legitimate in a strict sense (in relation to the claims of the original text); on the other hand, acknowledging that the translation is useful as a signpost for the modern reader (as long as it honestly marks its own limits). A signpost is not the destination, but signposts are useful.

(4) **Conditions for the use of the phrasing "adjacent / zone"**: This chapter frequently uses the phrasing "adjacent," "zone of mutual recognizability," "structurally adjacent," etc. These phrasings are not equivalent to "identical," "equivalent," or "corresponding." Wherever these phrasings are used, this chapter is marking a verifiable judgment: two independently constructed arguments, within the problem-domain of handling "the distance between mapping and the real," occupy structural positions that can be seen simultaneously; yet their respective philosophical loads, domains of operation, modes of argumentation, and ultimate orientations may differ, or even be opposite. Wherever this chapter cannot specify "in what sense adjacent," it does not use these phrasings. When marking structural relations between two independently constructed arguments or traditions, this chapter rejects equivalence phrasings such as "corresponds to," "is equivalent to," and "is precisely," because they would impose upon the reader a philosophical judgment this chapter does not intend to make. This is not a mechanical ban on ordinary emphatic uses within a sentence, concept definitions, or the translation of individual source-text words.

chained in a cave since childhood, able to see only the shadows cast on the cave wall. They take the shadows to be reality—their entire world consists of shadows. One person breaks free of his chains, walks out of the cave, and sees, for the first time, real objects illuminated by the sun. He returns to the cave and attempts to tell the others: what they see are merely shadows; the real is outside. The others do not believe him, and would even kill him.

This allegory is more than a mere metaphor. Upon it, Plato constructed an entire two-tier ontology: phenomena are shadows; the Forms are the real. The Forms are eternal, unchanging, perfect archetypes; concrete things in the sensible world are merely copies or shadows of the Forms. The relationship between shadows and Forms is unidirectional—the Forms determine the shadows; the shadows do not affect the Forms. The path out is the light of reason: through the training of reason—from mathematics to dialectics—the human soul can gradually ascend from the world of shadows to the world of Forms.

Plato believed that a reality exists independently of all readings, and that reason can bring people there. Plato's difficulty here and the difficulty of the person in the Clock Room share a similarity, and also a crucial difference. The similarity is: how does one infer the real from the shadows? The difference lies in: Plato believed that a person can walk out of the cave—can open the window. His entire philosophy is built upon this belief.

But the cave allegory itself extends a question that Plato did not fully unfold—read from the perspective of this book's framework, not from within Plato's own argument: after the person who walked out of the cave returns, his description—what he tells the others—is itself a kind of "shadow" (the use of "shadow" here is in the sense of this book's framework—referring to the mapping loss produced in the process of translation, not in the sense of "physical projection" in Plato's cave allegory). He saw the real, but the moment he translates the real into language, what he outputs is a new mapping. What the others receive is not the real, but a report about the real. Plato himself took "the light of reason out of the cave" as the main thread and did not directly address the mapping property of this act of "telling" itself. In the language of the Clock Room, this problem occupies an adjacent position to the structure of the third layer of irreversibility in Chapter 1: the act of expression possesses the key features of a mapping act—lossy transformation from high-dimensional to low-dimensional, the receiver's inability to directly return to the original real from the report. This chapter does not claim that language strictly satisfies the definition of a mapping function in Chapter 1, §3.4, but only marks this structural adjacency.

Plato's philosophy also has a consequence: it defines "the real" as the Form that must be reached through reason. Heidegger later treats this interpretation of Being as *idea* as the beginning of Western metaphysics: Being is understood as the Form through which beings come to appear. At the same time, he explicitly cautions that Plato's *idea* is not a representation in the consciousness of the modern "I-subject," and that the modern subject-object framework must not be projected back onto Plato (Heidegger, 1982). In this chapter's structural comparison, what can be marked is therefore a historically staged line of problems, not an identification of Plato with the modern subject-object divide: the interpretation of Being as Form initiates metaphysics, while the modern subject-object structure is a later formation. The Clock Room diagnoses, within this later formation, the slide from direct contact with the world into a subject-mode of confronting readings.

Return to the distinction made at the opening of this chapter—the intent of bridge-building, the structure of bridge-building—and read Plato. What Plato **intended** to build was a bridge: using the light of reason to bring people from this shore of shadows to the other shore of the Forms. The cave allegory, the Theory of Forms, the

ascent of the soul—all speak of how this bridge is to be built and traversed.

But within the geometry of Chapter 1, this bridge did not deliver anyone out of the cave. What it produced was a new layer of readings—the Forms are not a path leading outside the cave, but a layer of higher-order readings generated within the cave about the matter of "outside the cave." This layer of readings has its own use; it rearranges the world of shadows, ordering it according to a hierarchy that reason can judge; but it did not let anyone leave the cave. It added one more clock face within the cave.

This is the first form of bridge-building in Western metaphysics: **the intent was to cross over; what was accomplished was a superimposition.** What Plato himself saw was a bridge; viewed from Chapter 1, it was a new clock face. This form will repeatedly appear later in Descartes, Kant, and Hegel; only the materials of the bridge change—God, transcendental categories, dialectical movement. Yet the three stances differ: Descartes still promised the crossing, Kant delimited its scope, and Hegel sublated (Aufhebung) the two shores. The other shore, as the antithesis posited by the spirit (reason) of this shore itself, had to be "proven" within this shore—reinstalling the other shore within the dialectical course of the spirit's self-transcendence and self-realization.

§2.2 Descartes: Philosophizing the Situation of the Person in the Clock Room

Descartes (1596–1650) did something Plato did not do: he transformed the distance from "the world has two tiers" into "there is a distance between me and the world."

In the *Meditations on First Philosophy* (Descartes, 1641), he established the framework of representationalism. We can only directly contact the world of our ideas. External things can only be indirectly touched. Ideas and the things they represent are separated from one another—ideas are "inside" the mind; the things represented are "outside" the mind. Ideas can constitute accurate or false representations, but we have no direct channel to verify their correspondence to external things.

Structurally, Descartes' situation overlaps with that of the person in the Clock Room: between all readings (ideas) and the reality they represent (the external world) lies an interval that cannot be self-certified. But Descartes possessed something the person in the room does not—the certainty of the "I think" as a starting point.

Descartes also conceived of an extreme scenario: an all-powerful demon "has employed all his energies in order to deceive me," in whose scheme "the sky, the air, the earth, colours, shapes, sounds and all external things are merely the delusions of dreams which he has devised to ensnare my judgement" (Cottingham, Stoothoff, and Murdoch trans.). This demon bears a structural similarity to the scene in Chapter 1's fourth type of problem (the meta-information problem) where five new clocks intrude into the room—the person in the room does not know whether the one sending the clocks is helping or deceiving them. Both place the knower in a thoroughly uncertain mapping environment.

"I think, therefore I am" is the sole certainty Descartes found within the sealed room: "this proposition, I am, I exist, is necessarily true whenever it is put forward by me or conceived in my mind" (Descartes, 1641: Meditation II). But in the language of Chapter 1, the "I think" only proves that "there exists a person who is reading the clock"; it does not prove that "the clock points to the real time." The existence of the knowing subject is established, but the relationship between the subject and the world remains suspended.

Descartes ultimately used God to bridge the distance—he attempted to prove God's existence by natural reason

and to ground the reliability of clear and distinct ideas in God's not being a deceiver. This is a bridge. For this book, the question is not whether he offered a proof, but whether that proof provides independent calibration beyond the readings.

Descartes' solution laid the fundamental framework of the "subject-object dichotomy" for modern philosophy. Kant later called it a "scandal of philosophy" that the existence of external things should be accepted merely on faith and that no satisfactory proof could be offered to a doubter; in the same note, however, he also claimed to have provided a strict proof of the objective reality of outer intuition (Kant, 1781/1787: B xl note). This chapter borrows the problem he identified, rather than reducing his final position to the impossibility of proof. In the language of the Clock Room, what requires examination is the relation between readings and external reality; internal consistency among readings alone does not establish that this examination has been completed.

Return to the distinction made at the opening of this chapter—the intent of bridge-building, the structure of bridge-building—and read Descartes. What Descartes intended to build was also a bridge, but he relocated the site of bridge-building from "the world has two tiers" into the interior of the mind: the other shore was no longer the external world as a whole, but the single matter of "whether ideas correspond to external things." The "I think" was the bridgehead; God was the pier; clear and distinct ideas were the span; God's existence and non-deceptiveness were placed within this entire relation of guarantee.

Within the context of this chapter's thought experiment, Descartes' "I think" only proved that there exists a person reading the clock; an argument for God's non-deceptiveness does not automatically become an independent channel of calibration between reading and time merely by holding within the system. This bridge did not deliver anyone to the external things—what it produced was a new set of readings, second-order readings about "why ideas are reliable": clear and distinct ideas, a correspondence guaranteed by God, an internal order inaugurated by the "I think." This set of readings is tidy, has a foundation, but it remains on this shore; it added one more clock face within the room of the mind, a clock face inscribed with "Ideas Align with Reality," but no one can leave the room to verify whether this clock face itself is correct.[2]

The person in the room not only failed to leave the room; he also, from within the room, issued an appraisal certificate concerning "what lies outside the room." The validity of the certificate presupposes the appraising instrument; the existence of the appraised, conversely, has become a product of the instrument. This is precisely what the history of philosophy calls the "Cartesian circle"—clear and distinct ideas are used to prove God, and God is in turn used to guarantee clear and distinct ideas.

[2]This criticism has four mutually recognizable echoes outside this book; only the threads are marked here. The "Qiwulun" (Discussion on Making All Things Equal) chapter of the *Zhuangzi*: "What lies beyond the six directions, the sage leaves intact and does not discuss; what lies within the six directions, the sage discusses but does not appraise"; and in the same chapter, "to know to stop at what one does not know is the utmost" (Cao, 2024; author's translation)—an acknowledgment of the boundary of the not-known, neither proof nor denial. Heidegger, in "The Question Concerning Technology," writes that in the light of causality, "God can sink to the level of a cause" (Heidegger, 1977); according to Hsiao's recollection, he added after the lecture that, to prove God's existence by any of the traditional methods, "you thereby belittle Him, since God is something like the tao, which is ineffable" (Hsiao, 1987). Wang Defeng holds that once the human being takes God as an object of speech, the human being has already placed itself alongside God—the human being is the sayer, God is the said (Wang Defeng, public course *A Guided Reading of the Heart Sutra—Expounding the Mark of Emptiness Through the "Six Meanings"*, 2024). Feng Youlan, for his part, holds that the Chinese Confucian tradition neither proves God (bridge-building) nor merely stops short (leaving it undiscussed); rather, it **separates** the function of ritual from the truth or falsity of the proposition—suspending the knowledge-claim while retaining the emotional function (Feng Youlan, 1934).

§2.3 Kant: Acknowledging the Distance as Unbridgeable

Kant (1724–1804) took a different step from Descartes. He no longer attempted to bridge the distance—he acknowledged the distance as in principle unbridgeable. This chapter extracts only the facet of Kant's transcendental philosophy directly relevant to the mapping predicament; the full structure of the transcendental deduction and its ontological implications lie outside the scope of this chapter's discussion.

In the *Critique of Pure Reason*, he divided the real into Phenomena (Phaenomena) and Noumena (Things in Themselves). Phenomena are what we can experience—they are organized and presented through our forms of sensible intuition and categories of understanding. "Appearances, to the extent that as objects they are thought in accordance with the unity of the categories, are called phaenomena" (Kant, 1781/1787: A248/B305). Noumena are the real itself, independent of our experience—they exist, but cannot be directly accessed. If reason applies the categories of understanding to transcendent objects (noumena), it inevitably leads to "transcendental illusion."

Reading a certain local structure of Kant in the language of the Clock Room, the following comparison can be made: the position of "real time" shares with the noumenon the side of "not directly accessible"; the position of all clock readings shares with phenomena the side of "cognitively accessible"; Kant's conclusion that "we can only cognize phenomena, not noumena" structurally mirrors the same pattern as Chapter 1's "when the mapping function is completely unknown, the fiber is the full set." Yet this structural adjacency is not equivalent to equivalence in philosophical status: the noumenon in Kant is a transcendent ontological positing, while "the fiber is the full set" is a mathematical conclusion under given mapping conditions; marking this adjacency is meant to see how two sets of languages each handle different philosophical tasks at similar structural positions.

But Kant did not stop here. He preserved the order of the phenomenal realm: humans can never read time itself, but human readings are orderly within the phenomenal realm. The forms of sensible intuition—space and time—together with such categories of understanding as causality jointly constitute the transcendental conditions that make experience possible, even though experience can never reach the noumenon.

The bridge Kant built differed from those of Plato and Descartes. His bridge did not lead to the noumenon but lay within the phenomenal realm. He did not claim to be able to reach the real—he claimed to be able to establish reliable order within the world of readings. Reading this turn in the language of the Clock Room: although humans do not know the real time, they can establish consistent internal relations among the clock readings—Kant endowed this "internal consistency" with a transcendental philosophical status (it is not empirically induced, but the condition of the possibility of experience), while in the mathematical formulation of this book, what structurally parallels it is the "internal comparability of the set of readings under the condition that the mapping remains unchanged"; the two are structurally parallel, each carrying different philosophical loads.

Return to the distinction made at the opening of this chapter—the intent of bridge-building, the structure of bridge-building—and read Kant. Within the four-person sequence examined in this book, Kant is the first to openly acknowledge that "the bridge cannot reach the other shore"—the noumenon is in principle unreachable. But he did not give up building bridges; he merely shifted the location of bridge-building: no longer building a bridge between phenomena and noumena, but building a bridge within the phenomenal realm—building bridges between readings and readings. The transcendental categories are the materials for this new bridge.

The peculiarity of this bridge is that it acknowledges in advance that it cannot reach the other shore. What Kant

built is a bridge that does not lead to the other shore, only connecting readings to readings within this shore. Viewed from Chapter 1, what is the structure of this bridge? What it produced is a set of "rules of consistency among readings"—it installed a standard clock face on this shore, so that the number read from one clock and the number read from another clock have a principled way of being aligned. Readings are still readings; time itself remains out of reach; what was added were the graduations on this clock face.

The intent was to build a bridge honestly (acknowledging the noumenon cannot be reached); what was accomplished was organizing the world of readings on this shore with rigor. This is the shape, within Kant's philosophy, of what this book's mathematical formulation calls "the internal comparability of the set of readings under the condition that the mapping remains unchanged" (see earlier in this section).

§2.4 Hegel: Attempting to Bridge Through Dialectics

Hegel (1770–1831) did not accept Kant's limit. This chapter extracts only the structural facet of Hegelian dialectics directly relevant to the mapping predicament, and does not unfold the full form of dialectics in the *Phenomenology of Spirit*. He attempted, through dialectics—the self-negation and self-sublation of Spirit—to ultimately realize unity with the real in Absolute Knowledge.

In the *Phenomenology of Spirit*, Hegel maintained that "truth is not a minted coin that can be given and pocketed ready-made" (Hegel, 1807: Preface, §39). Truth is a process unfolded and comprehended in Spirit's self-movement. Spirit continually negates and sublates its own finite forms, ultimately attaining a conceptual comprehension of itself—Absolute Knowledge. In §808, Hegel describes history as Spirit's self-mediating becoming, estranged into time and returning to itself through recollection, and identifies Absolute Knowledge—Spirit knowing itself as Spirit—as its goal (Hegel, 1807: §808).

Reading Hegel in the language of the Clock Room, the following interpretation can be formed: each dialectical sublation (Aufhebung) expands the circle of cognition, until Spirit recognizes that mapping and the real are not two things—this is the summit of the progressive structure, which declares the dissolution of the distance. But whether this "dissolution" is equivalent to "perfect calibration" depends on whether one accepts Hegel's core premise (the self-identity of Concept and Reality). It must be noted: the word "calibration" itself presupposes a real independent of the knower—which is precisely what Hegel seeks to abolish; translating Hegel with "calibration" imposes a framework Hegel himself would not accept. Within the framework of this book, Hegel's core premise is itself a mapping that cannot be verified from within the system—a bridge about "abolishing bridges."

The third layer of irreversibility in Chapter 1, within the mathematical language of this book, reaches a counter-judgment on this declaration: when iteration merely recombines existing readings without introducing new information, the dimensions discarded by a dimension-reducing mapping cannot be recovered by any number of iterations. It must be honestly stated: Hegel himself would not formulate the relationship between Absolute Spirit and consciousness in terms of "dimensional difference"—"dimension" is not a Hegelian category. What is marked here is only: two sets of languages each independently touched upon this shared structural zone of "whether infinite approximation equals arrival"; within this zone, they reach opposite judgments—Hegel declares arrival; this book, under its given conditions, argues non-arrival. This is a collision between two independent arguments on a shared shape, not a revision of Hegel's text by this book.

Return to the distinction made at the opening of this chapter—the intent of bridge-building, the structure of

bridge-building—and read Hegel. What Hegel intended to do was greater than the three before him: he did not want to build a fixed bridge; he wanted the entire movement of bridge-building itself to become the bridge. Each dialectical sublation adds one more loop to cognition; the circles grow larger and larger, until Spirit recognizes—the bridge and the two shores are not three things, but three moments of a single thing. The bridge no longer needs to be built, because what was called the "distance" was merely the stretch of road Spirit had not yet traversed.

This is the highest ambition the enterprise of bridge-building can reach: not to build a bridge, but to let the absence of a bridge become the endpoint. Yet within the geometry of Chapter 1, this ambition is itself a bridge—a bridge about "abolishing bridges." That Spirit recognizes that mapping and the real are not two things—this recognition itself is a new layer of readings; dialectical movement sublates, merges, and upgrades all previous readings, and what is finally obtained is a clock face superimposing all the historical layers. Hegel declares the distance dissolved, but the dissolution was completed on this shore—it was a self-integration performed by Spirit within its own internal space, not someone actually walking to the other shore.

The intent was to let the bridge and the two shores vanish together; what was accomplished was superimposing the layers of bridges built across the ages into the most intricate clock face of all. Hegel's bridge is the most sophisticated, and also the most concealed—it hides itself within "movement," making one think that movement itself is arrival.

§2.5 From Plato to Hegel: A Progressive Structure

From Plato to Hegel, the differences among the four in their bridge-building are as follows:

- **Plato** believed bridges could lead to the real itself (the Forms), with reason as the material of the bridge.
- **Descartes** discovered the distance lay within the mind, using God and thought as piers to guarantee the correspondence of ideas to reality.
- **Kant** acknowledged the bridge cannot reach the real, turned to building bridges within the phenomenal realm, using the transcendental categories as the foundation for the order of phenomena.
- **Hegel** attempted to use infinite dialectical movement itself as the bridge—the bridge is not a fixed structure, but the entire process of self-movement.

Each generation was more soberly aware than the last of the depth of the distance. Yet the solution offered by each generation itself introduced a new set of conceptual architectures—these architectures constitute a second-order mapping of the mapping: the Forms are a second-order mapping of the real; God is a second-order mapping of certainty; the transcendental categories are a second-order mapping of the conditions of experience; dialectics is a second-order mapping of the movement of cognition. Every bridge is a new clock.

Von Neumann's experience, discussed in Chapter 1, is one contemporary node of this path. He had supported the program of proving the consistency of classical mathematics by finitistic methods; Gödel's second incompleteness theorem shows that no sufficiently strong consistent formal system can prove its own consistency, thereby imposing a fundamental limit on that program. What is limited here is a specific program of consistency proof, not axiomatic mathematics as a whole. Von Neumann later reassessed the grounds of absolute mathematical truth and continued to work within uncertainty. His three acts of self-negation thus form a three-stage narrative from confidence in the proof program, through encounter with its limits, to reassessment of the grounds of absolute mathematical truth. Chapter 1 treats this only as a bounded structural analogy: it neither identifies Gödel's

theorem with the irreversibility of mapping nor further determines whether his third intellectual transformation had been completed.

From the self-referencing of clocks to the reassembly of the knower, this structure will be unfolded in Chapter 3; this chapter only takes one node of it in the final section (§5).

§2.6 Husserl and Heidegger: Phenomenology's Revolt Against the Bridge-Building Tradition

From Plato to Hegel, bridge-building never ceased. The revolt against bridge-building within Western philosophy itself also never ceased—this line has existed continuously since skepticism. One of the most profound turns among them occurred at the beginning of the twentieth century, and it was phenomenology—Husserl (1859–1938) and his student Heidegger (1889–1976). What the teacher and student saw was the same thing: that set of things produced by human methods—the mathematical idealization of science, the Enframing of technology—no longer allowed itself to be seen as method, but in the name of "objective reality" substituted for that very thing humans originally set out to study. What the teacher and student did was also the same: no longer building a more sophisticated bridge, but returning to before the bridge was built. Yet the facets they each saw differed, and the remedies they each prescribed also differed; within the teacher-student relationship, there is both progression and tension.

§2.6.1 Husserl: The Garb of Ideas Concealing the Lifeworld

Husserl explained the same thing from another angle: in Western academia, each act of bridge-building draped one more garment over the lifeworld—even though the examples he cited were not Plato and Hegel, but Galileo and natural science. In §9 of *The Crisis of European Sciences and Transcendental Phenomenology* (hereafter *Crisis*), taking Galileo as his object of analysis, he delivered the following judgment:

> But now we must note something of the highest importance that occurred even as early as Galileo: the surreptitious substitution of the mathematically substructed world of idealities for the only real world, the one that is actually given through perception, that is ever experienced and experienceable—our everyday life-world. This substitution was promptly passed on to his successors, the physicists of all the succeeding centuries. (Husserl, 1936/1954: §9)

Galileo mathematized nature—using the precise idealities of geometry as a method, reducing nature to pure spatiotemporal forms that could be measured and calculated—and this undertaking itself possessed enormous predictive power. Husserl's diagnosis was not that the method was wrong, but that: the world of idealities produced by the method surreptitiously displaced the pre-scientific world that it was merely modeling. This pre-scientific world has a specific name in Husserl—the lifeworld (Lebenswelt)[3]: the embodied, directly experienced, not-yet-quantified-into-readings, colored, warm surrounding world.

He continued:

[3] "Lifeworld," as the most central concept of Husserl's late period, has its complete exposition concentrated in Part III A of the *Crisis* (§§28–55): "The Way into Phenomenological Transcendental Philosophy by Inquiring back from the Pregiven Life-World." This chapter's use of the lifeworld is limited to the structural position in which it appears in the §9 analysis of Galileo—"the pre-scientific, directly experienced world that is surreptitiously displaced by the mathematized ideality of nature"; the lifeworld in Husserl also has several other important facets (the constitutive foundation of intersubjectivity, the primordial bearer of historicity, the entry point to transcendental phenomenology), which lie beyond the scope of this chapter's discussion. For the textual history of the slogan "to the things themselves," see the editor's introduction to *The Methods of Phenomenology* (translated by Ni Liangkang, Shanghai: Shanghai Translation Publishing House, 2016) for a description of its evolution from the *Logical Investigations* to *Ideas* I.

> In geometrical and natural-scientific mathematization, in the open infinity of possible experiences, we measure the life-world—the world constantly given to us as actual in our concrete world-life—for a well-fitting **garb of ideas**, that of the so-called objectively scientific truths. … It is through the garb of ideas that we take for true being what is actually a method … (Husserl, 1936/1954: §9; emphasis added)

The "garb of ideas" (Ideenkleid) is a metaphor Husserl used for this substitution: the method of mathematization draped a garment over the lifeworld, and then the garment was taken for the body itself. Humans can no longer distinguish "a set of methodologically useful descriptions of the lifeworld" from "the true being of the lifeworld"—the former was taken for the latter.

Reading this diagnosis in the language of the Clock Room, the two sets of language can be aligned. **On the side of the lifeworld is time**—not yet sliced into readings, directly experienced, not yet exhausted by any antecedent system of mathematization or metricization. **On the side of the garb of ideas is the clock**—sliced readings, produced by method, taken for that which it covers. What Husserl called "the world of idealities surreptitiously displacing the lifeworld" is the shift Chapter 1 describes as entering the clock dimension from the time dimension—except this was stated earlier within Western philosophy. Husserl used "mathematized ideality vs. lifeworld"; this book uses "clock reading vs. time"—different points of departure, yet speaking of the same thing (here "the same thing" means the two occupy adjacent positions within the structural zone described above, not that their propositions are identical): the mapping produced by method is taken for that which it maps.

Husserl's concept of the "garb of ideas" gives the "intent of bridge-building / structure of bridge-building" distinction of this chapter's preceding four subsections a ready-made philosophical name. This book borrows it to redescribe the conceptual architectures of those subsections: each bridge built by Plato, Descartes, Kant, and Hegel can be described as a layer of the garb of ideas draped over the lifeworld—they themselves thought they were building bridges leading to the real, but what they built fell back onto the lifeworld, becoming a new garment, a new clock face. What Husserl names is Galileo and the modern natural sciences, not these four philosophers; this juxtaposition is a structural comparison made by this chapter, not a classification Husserl himself offered. The structure of the activity of bridge-building is a garment, is a clock, is not a bridge.

Husserl's remedy for this concealment was the general program of phenomenology—"zu den Sachen selbst"—**to the things themselves** (also translated "to the matters themselves"). This slogan first appeared in the *Logical Investigations* (1900–1901) as a methodological program, and was established as the methodological principle of phenomenology in *Ideas* I (1913). It is not an anti-science slogan—Husserl never demanded abandoning geometry, abandoning physics, returning to pre-scientific naïve intuition. What he demanded was something else: any scientific cognition must return to its starting point—return to that which was directly experienced in the lifeworld before the garb of ideas was draped over it—and in this regress, see clearly anew where it itself, as a scientific construction, comes from. Translated into the language of this book: use the clock, but be able at all times to return to the time that was directly experienced before the reading; **know that the clock is a methodological construction of time, not time itself.**

Categories stipulate facts, and conceal the things themselves—this sentence can serve as a summary of this diagnosis of Husserl. Once the categorical system produced by method (the garb of ideas) is taken as the framework of the real itself, it does two things: first, it no longer allows itself to be seen as merely method; second,

it in turn judges what is directly given in the lifeworld as "imprecise," "subjective," "secondary," "awaiting correction." The matter itself is concealed beneath the methodological garment covering it; and the act of concealment itself is in turn covered by the self-evidence of the methodological system, preventing the concealment from being seen. This is a formulation, in Husserl, of the three layers of irreversibility diagnosed in Chapter 1—especially the third layer of irreversibility.

Heidegger took this diagnosis further downward from Husserl, pushing it to the ontological layer, and gave its twentieth-century technological form a name—"Enframing" (Gestell).

§2.6.2 Heidegger: The Enframing of Technology and Resonances with the Turn Eastward

Heidegger diagnosed the substrate of two millennia of metaphysics as "the forgetting of Being"[4]: grounding Being in a supreme being, making everything present-at-hand into representable objects. Using the distinction between "readiness-to-hand" (Zuhandenheit) and "presence-at-hand," he locates the mode of existence of the human being in direct engagement with the world—a mode structurally adjacent to what Chapter 1 calls "working in time." Modern technology, however, almost thoroughly transforms this mode of existence into its opposite: technology as "Enframing" (Gestell) converts all things into measurable, calculable, orderable "standing-reserve" (Bestand), reducing the human being to an operator of readings. In this chapter's structural comparison, this diagnosis occupies a position adjacent to the ontological problem posed by the Clock Room under conditions of modern technology[5].

In 1946, Heidegger collaborated with the Chinese scholar Paul Shih-yi Hsiao on a translation of the *Tao Te Ching* (Ni & Fang, 2021), ultimately completing 8 of its 81 chapters (Hsiao, 1987). Hsiao recalled that this collaboration had a significant influence on Heidegger; he also recorded Heidegger's association of the Dao with ineffability. These materials establish Heidegger's contact with and attentiveness to Eastern thought, but they do not warrant attributing to him an explicit, complete program of overcoming the "subject-object dichotomy" and the "Enframing of technology" through an Eastern language. In this chapter's structural reading, the contact nevertheless suggests a path of rethinking Western metaphysics through Eastern languages and perspectives. This is only the chapter's interpretation, not a purported statement of Heidegger's own complete program. A thinker who profoundly diagnosed the predicament of Western metaphysics also turned his gaze toward the East. This chapter takes up this gaze and enters §3.

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[4]For Heidegger's judgment on the "onto-theo-logical" structure of Western metaphysics and the "forgetting of Being," see Martin Heidegger, *Identity and Difference* (translated by Joan Stambaugh, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2002); and *Being and Time* (translated by Macquarrie & Robinson, Oxford: Blackwell, 1962) §4, on the following determination of Dasein: in its Being, this Being itself is at issue for it. For a Chinese-language secondary survey, see Zhang Rulun, *Fifteen Lectures on Modern Western Philosophy* (Beijing: CITIC Press Group, 2020). (In Chinese.)

[5]The classic sources for "readiness-to-hand" (Zuhandenheit), "Enframing" (Gestell), and "standing-reserve" (Bestand) are, in order: Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time: A Revised Edition of the Stambaugh Translation* (translated by Joan Stambaugh, Albany: SUNY Press, 2010) §15; *The Question Concerning Technology and Other Essays* (translated by William Lovitt, New York: Harper & Row, 1977); and *Nietzsche*, Vol. IV: *Nihilism* (edited and translated by David Farrell Krell, San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1982), for the judgment that modern technology is the final completion of metaphysics' long process of forgetting Being. For Latour's summary of Enframing, see Bruno Latour, *We Have Never Been Modern* (translated by Catherine Porter, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1993): "technology – that pure Enframing (Zimmerman, 1990) of being [Ge-Stell], that ineluctable fate [Geschick], that supreme danger [Gefahr]." For a Chinese secondary discussion, see Hu Yilin, *What Is Technology* (Changsha: Hunan Science and Technology Press, 2020): "Modern technology pre-establishes for the entire world a certain overall framework, within which anything, before it is actually unearthed, has already been pre-excavated." (author's translation)

§3 Important Ontological Nodes in the East

The mainstream of Western metaphysics treated the distance as a problem to be bridged: Plato's Forms, Descartes' God, Kant's transcendental categories, Hegel's dialectics—each generation built more sophisticated bridges.

Within Eastern lines of thought, there exists another path. They are not the "opposite of the Western mainstream"—not replacing "bridge-building" with "questioning bridges"; they set out from different places and walked in different directions, yet can be seen simultaneously at a single point: none of them treated the distance as a problem needing to be bridged. In their languages, there is not even the word "distance."

The following selects four nodes: Laozi, the Diamond Sutra, the Sixth Patriarch Huineng, and Lu Jiuyuan with Wang Yangming. The so-called "common zone"—the phrasing with which §3.5 will conclude the structural comparison of the four schools—is not the conceptual commensurability of the four teachings, but the fact that each of them, in its own distinct way, loosens the impulse that "one must pass through better mappings to arrive at the real"; the manner, depth, and direction of this loosening all differ. The subsequent nodes will not redefine this formulation; §3.5 will only provide a structural summary.

A note on the form of narration: §2 adopted a progressive causal chain for the Western path (Plato → Descartes → Kant → Hegel), while the four nodes of this section are presented in a juxtaposed arrangement. This asymmetry does not imply a substantive judgment that "the East has no progressive history"—the Eastern tradition certainly has its own independent lines of intellectual evolution (such as the progression of Chan Buddhism from Indian dhyāna to the Five Houses and Seven Schools of Chinese Buddhism, or the three-hundred-year evolution of Song-Ming Neo-Confucianism); but this chapter focuses on the problem-domain of "how the mapping gap is handled," and within this domain, the four schools provide different nodes in the same direction, rather than a progressive chain responding to one another. Presenting them in juxtaposition rather than progression more accurately reflects their relationship within this chapter's problem-domain.

On the twofold legitimacy of translation: The use of Eastern nodes in §3 is translational—translating a set of texts that do not share its point of departure using the language of Chapter 1; its legitimacy, limits, and other methodological qualifications (the operationality of node selection, the representativeness of node selection, the asymmetry of translation, the conditions for the use of the phrasing "adjacent / zone") are uniformly collected in footnote 1.

§3.1 Laozi: The Dao That Can Be Spoken Is Not the Constant Dao

Laozi (c. 6th century BCE): "The Dao that can be described in language is not the constant Dao" (*Tao Te Ching*, Chapter 1; Lynn, 1999).

This sentence is not "the real is hard to approach"—that is Kant's position. What Laozi is saying is: **that which can be spoken, named, mapped, is not the constant dao.** The act of mapping is itself the starting point of the problem, not the solution. Plato believed that walking out of the cave would allow one to see the light; Laozi says, even if one sees the light, the moment one describes the light in language, what is spoken is no longer the light itself.

From this starting point, Laozi offered a functional theory of "non-being" (*wu*). Chapter 11 of the *Tao Te Ching*:

> Thirty spokes share one hub. It is exactly where there is nothing of it that the functionality of the

wheel resides.

Mix clay with water to make a vessel. It is exactly where there is nothing of it that the functionality of the vessel resides.

Cut doors and windows to make a room. It is exactly where there is nothing of it that the functionality of the room resides.

Therefore this is how what is there provides benefit and how what is not there provides functionality. (Lynn, 1999)

The source of function lies in "non-being," not in "being." The function of the wheel comes from the emptiness of the axle hole, not the solidity of the spokes. The function of the bowl comes from the cavity enclosed by its inner walls, not the solidity of the clay. The function of the room comes from the emptiness of the doors and windows, not the solidity of the walls.

In Laozi's own language, he was speaking of the power of "non-being." In an entirely different language—the framework of this book—a certain structural adjacency can be observed: the "non-being" of the hub and the unoccupied portion of the human biological substrate (the embodied cognitive architecture through which human beings contact the world through multiple channels; its full definition will be given in Chapter 3); the "non-being" of the vessel and the work space of meta-audit capacity (the capacity to examine the provenance and reliability of one's own judgments; its full definition will be given in Chapter 3); the "non-being" of the room and the channel of causal contact (the external reference, independent of the set of readings and in causal contact with the real, required by Definition 4 of Chapter 1). These traditions took shape independently and were not produced by this book's translation; but their comparability with the framework of this book is established by this book's structural reading. Laozi did not speak of a "biological substrate"; he spoke of a carriage hub. **The value of these analogies does not lie in revealing Laozi's "original meaning"—that lies beyond the scope and capacity of this chapter—but in demonstrating: at the far end from the Western epistemological tradition, there exists a profound insight into the function of "emptiness," and this insight provides unexpected conceptual resources for critiquing the "overload" of the contemporary information environment.**

"Therefore this is how what is there provides benefit and how what is not there provides functionality." The design direction of the information environment—faster transmission, fuller information flows, more seamless interaction—each of these is eliminating "non-being." What Laozi is saying is something else: do not fill it up.

§3.2 The Diamond Sutra: Sands of the Ganges and Recursive Self-Negation

The Buddha (c. 5th century BCE), in the *Vajracchedikā Prajñāpāramitā Sūtra* (Diamond Sutra, translated by Kumārajīva, 402 CE), pushed the state of existence to a logical limit.

First, consider the sands of the Ganges. Chapter 11:

> "Subhuti, I am telling you the truth. If a good man or good woman filled as many billion-world universes as grains of sand in that many Ganges Rivers with precious substances, and used all that to give in charity, would there be much blessing gained?" Subhuti said, "Very much, World Honored One." The Buddha said to Subhuti, "If a good man or a good woman accepts and holds even the equivalent of a four-line verse of this sutra, and tells it to others, the blessing in this exceeds the aforementioned blessing." (Cleary, 1998)

Chapter 18 again uses this layered image of the sands of the Ganges:

> "Subhuti, what do you think—does the Buddha say the grains of sand in the Ganges River are sand?"
> "Yes, World Honored One. The Realized One says they are sand."
> "Subhuti, what do you think—if there were as many Ganges Rivers as there are grains of sand in the Ganges River, would buddha-worlds as numerous as grains of sand in that many Ganges Rivers be many?"
> "Very many, World Honored One." (Cleary, 1998)

Sands of the Ganges multiplied by sands of the Ganges. The sutra first imagines as many Ganges Rivers as there are grains of sand in one Ganges, and then refers to the sands in all those rivers and to the corresponding buddha-worlds. The emphasis is on an incalculable, layer-upon-layer expansion.

In the terms of this book's thought experiment, one can imagine a room containing a trillion clocks, or N clocks each with a trillion internal parameters. The accumulation of clocks, parameters, and readings does not automatically disclose real time by virtue of sheer quantity. Whether calibration is possible still depends on human subjectivity. Accordingly, the blessing of giving alms with the seven precious jewels filling as many three-thousand-great-thousandfold worlds as there are sands of the Ganges is less than the blessing of accepting and upholding a four-line verse[6].

Readings as numerous as the sands of the Ganges remain readings, not the Ganges itself. The Diamond Sutra and this chapter share a structural feature: **the accumulation of quantity does not equal a qualitative leap.** The insight that "readings as numerous as the sands of the Ganges are not the Ganges" holds its value independently of the number of readings (N).

Next, consider recursive self-negation. The core logical pattern of the Diamond Sutra is: "X is not X; therefore it is called X." The Buddha speaks of prajñāpāramitā; it is not prajñāpāramitā; therefore it is called prajñāpāramitā. The Tathāgata speaks of the world; it is not the world; therefore it is called the world. In the Diamond Sutra's own language, the function of this pattern is not to make a logical judgment, but immediately to loosen anything named into something "not to be abided in" and distinct from the naming itself.

But the Diamond Sutra does not stop there. It recursively applies the same negation to all such acts of naming—including the negation of this very application. If one clings to the result of a particular negation, holding it as the ultimate truth, one manufactures a name for the "negation"—turning the negation of naming itself back into a naming. (It must be noted: the Diamond Sutra's "is not… therefore it is called…" is not the negation of formal logic, but an **ontological unbinding**—its purpose is to prevent one from dwelling in any conceptual framework. It bears a **metaphorical** similarity to Gödel's theorem at the point of "self-reference leading to predicament," but the two differ entirely in their domain of operation, mode of argumentation, and ultimate orientation. This chapter only takes their analogizability on the structure of "infinite regress.")

The Diamond Sutra's prescription, as rendered in the Platform Sutra narrative, is "You should activate the

[6]The Diamond Sutra repeatedly refers to a "four-line verse." This chapter does not restrict it to one fixed set of sentences; the following three passages are selected to illustrate different facets of this chapter's discussion. One, Chapter 32: "All created things are / like dreams, illusions, bubbles, shadows; / like dew, and like lightning. / They should be viewed in this way." (Cleary, 1998)—pointing out the impermanence of all phenomena. Two, Chapter 26: "Anyone who sees me in form, / Or who seeks me through sound, / Is traveling a false path / And cannot see the Realized One." (Cleary, 1998)—dismantling attachment to the external appearances of the Buddha. Three, Chapter 5: "All appearances are illusory; / if you see that appearances are not characteristics, / then you see the Realized One." (Cleary, 1998)—in this chapter's reading, connected with the state of seeing-nature where "one abides nowhere." The three passages have different emphases; this chapter uses them to mark the same structure: readings as numerous as the sands of the Ganges are not the Ganges.

mind without dwelling on anything" (Cleary, 1998): not dwelling in any mapping (including the mapping that "mapping is not the real"), yet still maintaining awareness. The self-referential passage of Chapter 1, §7.1—if the reader accepts its conclusion merely through the narrative force of the argument, without returning to their own experience for the ontological part or examining the argumentative logic for the formal part, one more internally consistent clock has merely been added to the room—occupies the same zone as the Diamond Sutra's recursion. The Diamond Sutra says it even more directly: "even the truth is to be relinquished, let alone nontruth." (Cleary, 1998)

§3.3 The Sixth Patriarch Huineng: Between Delusion and Awakening

This chapter takes the figure of the Sixth Patriarch Huineng presented in the Zongbao edition as its principal object of reading, checking key points against the Dunhuang edition; in the Zongbao narrative, the problem shifts from "is the mapping correct?" to "who is doing the mapping?" (*The Platform Sutra of the Sixth Patriarch*)[7].

The lowliest may possess the highest wisdom. The "Personal History" chapter of the *Platform Sutra* records that when Huineng first arrived at Huangmei, the Fifth Patriarch asked: "You are a southerner, and an aborigine; how can you be a buddha?" (Cleary, 1998) Huineng replied:

> "People may be southerners or northerners, but the buddha-nature originally has no south or north. As an aborigine, my social status is not the same as yours, but what difference is there in our buddha-nature?" (Cleary, 1998)

Later, when Zhang Riyong, the lieutenant inspector, marveled that Huineng too would compose a verse, Huineng replied:

> "A person of the lowliest rank may have the very highest knowledge, while a person of the highest rank may lack practical wisdom." (Cleary, 1998)

This is saying: **cognitive capacity and the state of existence are two different things.** The capacity to process readings (the cleverness of "the highest") does not equal the capacity to calibrate. Indeed, cleverness may allow one to adapt more quickly to a wrong mapping system without feeling discomfort anymore. The lack of practical wisdom named in the passage can be read here as wisdom obscured by one's own cleverness. Read in this book's

[7]The quotations from the *Platform Sutra* in this chapter follow the Zongbao edition (*The Platform Sutra of the Sixth Patriarch*, Taishō No. 2008, compiled by Zongbao in the 28th year of the Zhiyuan era of the Yuan dynasty [1291]; this is the most widely circulated edition from the Ming dynasty onward). The Deyi edition was published in the 27th year of the Zhiyuan era [1290]; the two editions appeared independently, a year apart, and are not successive revisions of the same edition. There also exists the Dunhuang edition (*Nanzong dunjiao zuishang dasheng mohe bore boluomi jing Liuzu Huineng dashi yu Shaozhou Dafansi shifa tan jing* [The Southern School Sutra of the Supreme Mahayana Great Perfection of Wisdom, on the Dharma Platform of the Sixth Patriarch Huineng at Dafan Temple in Shaozhou], Taishō No. 2007; the extant Dunhuang manuscript was copied between 830 and 860 CE and is the earliest extant text of the *Platform Sutra*; it is a copy of an earlier version, some of whose material dates to around 780; Yampolsky, 1967). The two editions exhibit textual differences in the key verses: Huineng's first verse in response to Shenxiu reads in the Zongbao edition, "Enlightenment originally has no tree, / And a clear mirror is not a stand. / Originally there's not a single thing— / Where can dust be attracted?" (Cleary, 1998); the Dunhuang edition instead reads, "Bodhi originally has no tree, / The mirror also has no stand. / Buddha nature is always clean and pure; / Where is there room for dust?" (Yampolsky, 1967) (See Guo Peng, *Collated Annotations on the Platform Sutra*, Beijing: Zhonghua Book Company, 1983; Jinghui, *The New Dunhuang Edition of the Platform Sutra of the Sixth Patriarch*, Shanghai: Shanghai Classic Publishing House, 1993). The philosophical implications of the two lines are not entirely equivalent—"Originally there is not a single thing" is a negating dismantling, while "Buddha nature is always clean and pure" affirms original endowment. In this verse, the chapter takes the negating facet of the Zongbao reading, "Originally there is not a single thing"; the later citation in §3.3 of the five sentences beginning "Who would have expected that inherent nature is originally intrinsically pure?" presents the affirmative facet of the later Zongbao narrative. What coexist here are two tendencies presented by different textual versions and their reception history; they cannot, without further argument, be combined into a completed two-sided structure within the historical Huineng's own thought (Yampolsky, 1967). This chapter selects the Zongbao edition for its mainstream status in reception history since the Ming, not because it is textually more "authentic."

terms: the lowliest, because they have less of this cleverness, may instead preserve something. This something occupies an adjacent zone to the signal recognition described in Chapter 1's fourth type of problem—recognizing the event itself as a signal requiring explanation, a metacognition that occurs prior to the processing of the event: this discomfort is not deduced from cleverness; it is a more fundamental signal recognition.

Shenxiu and Huineng. The Fifth Patriarch asked his disciples to present verses. Shenxiu (606–706) wrote:

> The body is the tree of enlightenment,
> The mind is like a clear mirror-stand.
> Polish it diligently time and again,
> Not letting it gather dust. (Cleary, 1998)

Shenxiu acknowledges that there is dust, which needs to be continuously cleared away. This is a state of infinite approximation—approaching the ideal limit of "dust is zero" through infinite diligence.

Huineng responded with a verse:

> Enlightenment originally has no tree,
> And a clear mirror is not a stand.
> Originally there's not a single thing—
> Where can dust be attracted? (Cleary, 1998)

Huineng's verse is not negating Shenxiu's diligence, but rejecting Shenxiu's framework—if "dust" only becomes a problem when the subject clings to "there being something for dust to alight on," then the solution is not more diligent polishing. This is another direction: not "dust cannot be eliminated," but "dust is the product of a state of existence."

The Zongbao edition then gives a further, affirmative expression: when Huineng heard the Fifth Patriarch expound the Diamond Sutra to the phrase "You should activate the mind without dwelling on anything" (Cleary, 1998), he had a great awakening and said to the Patriarch:

> Who would have expected that inherent nature is originally intrinsically pure?
> Who would have expected that inherent nature is originally unborn and undying?
> Who would have expected that inherent nature is originally complete in itself?
> Who would have expected that inherent nature is originally immovable?
> Who would have expected that inherent nature can produce myriad things? (Cleary, 1998)

These five sentences are often overlooked, but within the Zongbao narrative they supply an affirmative expression distinct from the negating verse. The verse negates—"originally there is not a single thing," dismantling Shenxiu's framework. These five sentences affirm—"Who would have expected that inherent nature is originally complete in itself?" They do not say "there is nothing at all," but that **there is no need to seek outwardly.** This is a transformation of the state of existence in the figure of Huineng presented by the Zongbao edition, not an epistemological proposition that this book can directly attribute to the historical Huineng without textual-layer argument.

When deluded, a Buddha is a sentient being; when awakened, a sentient being is a Buddha. The *Platform Sutra* returns repeatedly to this judgment: "If your own nature is confused, you are an ordinary person; if your own nature is awakened, you are a buddha." (Cleary, 1998) "It is just because of the ordinary beings that you

lose sight of buddha; it is not buddha that loses sight of ordinary beings." (Cleary, 1998) Buddha and sentient beings are not two fixed entities, but a transformation of state between delusion and awakening. It is not that there are two worlds (phenomena and reality), but that there are two states of existence. Transformation is not walking from one world to another; it is changing one's relationship to mapping.

It is not the wind that moves; it is not the banner that moves; it is your mind that moves. The "Personal History" chapter of the *Platform Sutra* records that Huineng arrived at the Faxing Monastery in Guangzhou:

> At the time there was a wind blowing, and the pennants were flapping. One monk said, "The wind is moving." Another said, "The pennants are moving." They argued on and on, so I came forward and said, "It is not the wind moving, it is not the pennants moving; it is your minds moving." (Cleary, 1998)

The two monks were arguing at the level of readings—was the wind moving, or the banner moving? Annotating Huineng's understanding with the Clock Room: the argument arises because the knowers have already projected themselves into the mapping. The two were arguing about which reading was correct, but the very fact that "they were arguing" already indicates the problem—the arguers had already left direct contact and entered the mutual comparison of readings. In direct contact, one does not need to compare—wind, banner, and perception are different facets of a single event, not yet discretized into "subject" and "object." Huineng is not saying "the mind created the movement of the wind and the banner"—that would be idealism. **Huineng's response points toward a state of awareness:** there, wind, banner, and perception have not yet been cut into the opposition of "subject" and "object." Huineng's point is practical: stop arguing within the conceptual fragments produced by discretization, and return to that awareness itself, before it was split.

Not relying on written words. That Huineng did not depend on written words has another direct piece of evidence within the original text. After Huineng made his appearance with the "wind and banner debate," the Dharma Master Yinzong exchanged a few words with him; the text records: "**He saw that my speech was simple and my reasoning was accurate; and that this did not come from writings**" (Cleary, 1998). The four-character Chinese phrase rendered here as "not relying on written words" marks not a deficiency in cognitive ability, but a path of approaching meaning that does not detour through written words as tools on the level of beings. Commentarial annotations on the *Platform Sutra* regarding "Huineng was illiterate" also clarify this distinction: the original meaning of Huineng's illiteracy is that he could not read, recognize, or write written characters, not that he could not discern or analyze the meaning of written words—he still had profound comprehension of the meaning carried by written words, only he was not bound by written words.[8]

The thought of the Sixth Patriarch Huineng marks a position: not "building a better bridge," not "acknowledging the distance as unbridgeable," but **returning to before discretization**—returning to that state of contact where "the wind, the banner, and the person had not yet been separated." Whether this position is epistemologically

[8] It must be specifically noted: the eight characters "not establishing written words; a special transmission outside the teachings" (bu li wen zi, jiao wai bie chuan), often cited as the hallmark of Chan Buddhism, do not come from the main text of the *Platform Sutra* but are a summary of the overall orientation of Chan Buddhism by later generations (such as the *Record of the Transmission of the Lamp of the Jingde Era* and the *Compendium of the Five Lamps*), traditionally attributed to the first patriarch Bodhidharma. This section therefore handles the matter with caution—the anchor point in the original text is "not relying on written words" and "the inherent nature is originally complete in itself, not seeking outwardly"; "not establishing written words" is not cited as an original phrase from the *Platform Sutra*. Wang Defeng, in his lectures on "The Contemporary Significance of Yangming's School of Mind," offers an intuitive metaphor: written words, in relation to realizing the Way, are like a ladder to ascend a tower—the ladder must be used, and only after ascending the tower can it be removed. "Breaking through the barrier of words" refers to removing the ladder after ascending the tower, not "not using the ladder." This safeguard is necessary to avoid misreading "not relying on written words" as anti-intellectualism. (author's translation)

articulable, and whether it can be operationalized within a mapping system, is another question. But it marks a direction that repeatedly appears: the problem is not that the mapping is insufficiently good, but that human beings have forgotten how they entered into the mapping in the first place.[9]

§3.4 Lu Jiuyuan and Wang Yangming: The Mind Is Principle and the Extension of Innate Knowledge

Song-Ming Neo-Confucianism divides into two major lines: the Cheng-Zhu School of Principle and the Lu-Wang School of Mind. The dispute between the two lines appears on the surface to be a single-word difference between "nature is principle" and "mind is principle," but in its bones, it is about two answers to a fundamental question—where does Heavenly Principle reside? Is it an object suspended high above the human mind, which the mind must strive upward to reach, or is it originally present within every person's mind, such that once the mind becomes self-aware, it is directly principle itself? This is not an abstract metaphysical dispute; it is a judgment about the position of the human being in the world, a judgment about where moral authority lies, a judgment about whether ordinary people in a culture can stand up and become subjects.

§3.4.1 Lu Jiuyuan: The Mind Is Principle

Lu Jiuyuan (1139–1193), known to the world as Master Xiangshan, laid the foundations of the Lu-Wang School of Mind. He was a contemporary of Zhu Xi, and the two were fundamentally opposed in their scholarly positions. Zhu Xi advocated "investigating things to extend knowledge" (ge wu zhi zhi)—accumulating Heavenly Principle by examining concrete things one by one; Lu Jiuyuan did not accept this path—Principle does not need to be investigated outwardly, because "the mind is principle."

The mind is principle. Lu Jiuyuan directly states in his "Miscellaneous Discourses" (*Collected Works of Master Xiangshan*, juan 22):

> The four directions plus upward and downward constitute the spatial continuum (yü). What has gone by in the past and what is to come in the future constitute the temporal continuum (chou). The universe (these continua) is my mind, and my mind is the universe. Sages appeared tens of thousands of generations ago. They shared this mind; they shared this principle. Sages will appear tens of thousands of generations to come. They will share this mind; they will share this principle. Over the four seas sages appear. They share this mind; they share this principle. (Chan, 1963a)[10]

[9] Feng Youlan, in *A Short History of Chinese Philosophy*, points out that Chan Buddhism has two sayings often repeated: "the very mind is Buddha" and "not-mind, not-Buddha." Shenxiu's verse expresses the former; Huineng expresses the latter. And when someone asked Mazu, Huineng's disciple's disciple, "Why do you say that the very mind is Buddha?" Ma-tsu answered: "I simply want to stop the crying of children." "Suppose they do stop crying?" asked the questioner. "Then not-mind, not-Buddha," was the answer. (Feng Youlan, 1948)—Even the formulation "the very mind is Buddha" is merely an expedient means, not the ultimate truth. Master Nanquan further said: "The Tao is not classifiable as either knowledge or non-knowledge. Knowledge is illusory consciousness and non-knowledge is blind unconsciousness." (Feng Youlan, 1948)—Transcending the dualistic opposition of knowing and not-knowing. These three dimensions—negating any conceptual framework, every formulation being merely an expedient, transcending the duality of knowing/not-knowing—are far richer than "the cut itself is a later addition." This chapter marks this multiplicity here, without implying any single interpretation as the only one.

[10] Lu Jiuyuan's original text has an asymmetry in the parallelism: "the universe **is precisely** my mind; my mind **is** the universe" (yu zhou bian shi wu xin; wu xin ji shi yu zhou; author's translation), the first half using "bian shi" ("is precisely"), the second half using "ji shi" ("is"). Transmitted abridgements and popular editions often regularize the phrasing to either "bian shi" or "ji shi," losing the original form. The Chinese text follows the traditional-character original text of the *Ruzang* edition (see References for edition information) and preserves this asymmetry in its simplified-character transcription; Chan's published English translation quoted in §3.4.1 regularizes both clauses as "is." Wang Defeng, in discussing Confucian philosophy of mind, repeatedly prompts a distinction: "This humaneness (ren) is not a concept in the head, but our mind (xin) … Ren is in the mind, not in the head" (lecture on "The Contemporary Significance of Yangming's School of Mind"; author's translation from an edited video transcript, with homophonic transcription errors corrected according to context). The "mind" in Lu Jiuyuan's "the mind is principle" is not synonymous with the head (the organ of cognition), but that dimension where the human being, beyond being an existent, also dwells at the level of Being. This distinction is necessary to

This passage is not "the mind creates the universe"—that would be a modern idealist misreading of the passage. Lu Jiuyuan himself also says: "There is of course concrete principle in the universe" (Chan, 1963a). What he denies is not the independent existence of principle, but the separation of principle from the mind—principle is not an object external to the human being that needs to be collected piece by piece through investigating things; principle is right within every person's mind, and every person's mind is connected at this layer.[11]

Borrowing the language of Chapter 1: principle is not some true value awaiting approximation outside the room; principle is at that layer where every person in the room co-dwells.

The affairs of the universe are precisely one's own share of affairs. Lu Jiuyuan continues immediately at the same place (*Collected Works of Master Xiangshan*, juan 22, "Miscellaneous Works"):

> The affairs in the universe (yü-chou) are my own affairs. My own affairs are affairs of the universe. (Chan, 1963a)

This sentence offers the Clock Room an ontological point of entry: the affairs on the side of the universe are precisely the affairs on one's own side; there is no need to build a bridge to go across—the very impulse to build a bridge already presupposes two ends. When a person posits themselves as a "subject confronting an object," they have already performed a self-division: placing "the affairs of the universe" on the side of "affairs beyond one's own share," and then asking "how to get from this side to that side." What this chapter examines on this basis is how such division deepens the human being's estrangement from the world; the mapping, fiber, and irreversibility of Chapter 1, however, do not take this division as their logical starting point. Whenever a true state is compressed into a reading through a mapping, the fiber may be non-singleton; under the usual spatial conditions, the information lost through continuous dimension reduction likewise does not depend on whether the knower is aware of a subject-object division.

Human beings themselves limit and separate themselves from the universe. Lu Jiuyuan has another sentence that even more directly hits the diagnosis of the Clock Room in Chapter 1 (*Collected Works of Master Xiangshan*, juan 34, "Recorded Sayings, Part I"):

> The universe has never separated itself from man. Man separates himself from the universe. (Chan, 1963a)

Lu Jiuyuan's statement that "man separates himself from the universe" indicates one way in which the predicament is intensified ontologically. A clock, as a mapping apparatus, is already distinct from time; when a person repeatedly substitutes a single clock reading for multi-channel contact that can ordinarily be cross-checked, their estrangement from time deepens further. "Self-separation" can thus explain why a person becomes more liable to mistake readings for the real, but it cannot replace the conditions under which each of Chapter 1's three layers of irreversibility independently holds.

The superior person governs things. Lu Jiuyuan also has a sentence that is a direct warning for the Clock

avoid misreading the School of Mind as a "philosophy of subjective consciousness."

[11] In discussing "the mind is principle," JeeLoo Liu interprets "ji" (即) as expressing the inseparability of mind and principle rather than their simple identification. "In claiming the mind is principle, Lu Xiangshan is not saying that the law of the universe is the mind's construction and thus depends on the mind for its existence" (Liu, 2018: ch. 6). Lu Jiuyuan himself also says: "Principle exists in the universe from the very beginning. How can it be said to be non-being?" (*Collected Works of Master Xiangshan*, juan 2, letter to Zhu Yuanhui; Chan, 1963a). Feng Youlan marks the difference between the Cheng-Zhu and Xiangshan lines in terms of two worlds and one world: in the reality Zhu Xi saw there are two worlds, one beyond space and time and one within it; in the reality Lu Jiuyuan saw there is only one world, in which mind and universe are one body (Feng Youlan, *A History of Chinese Philosophy*, Chapter 14).

Room (*Collected Works of Master Xiangshan*, juan 35, "Recorded Sayings, Part II"):

> The gentleman makes things his servants. The petty man is servant to things. Authority lies entirely with me; if it lies instead with things, then I am enslaved by them. (first sentence after Hutton's rendering of the *Xunzi*, from which Lu quotes verbatim; second sentence: author's translation)

When a person entirely calibrates clocks with clocks, and defines themselves by clock readings—what the reading points to, what the reading reports, whether the readings are mutually consistent—the person is enslaved by things. The literal counterpart of "enslaved by things" is precisely what Chapter 1, §5 describes as "slipping from working in time to working on clocks." Lu Jiuyuan has another sentence echoing this, a proposition of the School of Mind: "If in our study we know the fundamentals, then all the Six Classics are my footnotes." (Chan, 1963a)—classical texts are not external authorities independent of one's own cultivated judgment, but corroborations after the mind has first established itself.

The limits of Lu Jiuyuan. Lu Jiuyuan had already proposed methods of self-cultivation; "be the master of oneself" and "first establish the greater part" are not merely propositions detached from practice. Feng Youlan's judgment is that the School of Mind was only begun by Lu Jiuyuan and Yang Jian, its culmination awaiting Wang Yangming: "Thus the real rival of Chu Hsi is neither Lu nor Yang, but their illustrious follower, Wang Shou-jen, who lived two and a half centuries later." (Feng Youlan, *A History of Chinese Philosophy*, Chapter 14; Bodde translation). This judgment does not mean that Lu's teaching lacked practices of cultivation; it distinguishes Lu's teaching from its later culmination in Wang Yangming. Lu Jiuyuan established the propositions—the mind is principle, the universe is my mind, humans themselves separate themselves from the universe—and also offered corresponding paths of cultivation; "how to unfold 'the mind is principle' in action" was developed further by Wang Yangming.

§3.4.2 Wang Yangming: The Unity of All Things Through Humaneness (ren) and the Extension of Innate Knowledge

Wang Yangming (1472–1529), inspired by Lu Jiuyuan, founded the School of Mind. In his later poem "Four Verses on Pure Knowing Written for My Students," no. 3, in *Complete Works of Wang Yangming*, "Outer Collection II," he wrote:

> Everyone has within an unerring compass; The root and source of the myriad transformations lies in the heart-mind. I laugh when I think that, earlier, I saw things the other way around; Following branches and leaves, I searched outside! (Ivanhoe, 2009)

This poem is both a negation of Zhu Xi's path of "investigating things outwardly" and a practical continuation of Lu Jiuyuan's proposition that "the mind is principle."

In his *Inquiry on the Great Learning*, Wang Yangming gave the positive formulation of the School of Mind:

> The great man regards Heaven and Earth and the myriad things as one body. He regards the world as one family and the country as one person. As to those who make a cleavage between objects and distinguish between the self and others, they are small men. That the great man can regard Heaven, Earth, and the myriad things as one body is not because he deliberately wants to do so, but because it is natural to the humane nature of his mind that he do so. (Chan, 1963a)

This is not merely the normative demand that "humans ought to regard the myriad things as one body"; it is

also an ontological description of the original state: **the humaneness of the mind was originally one body.** The separation of self and other by the barrier of physical form (distinguishing self from other, subject from object) is a later division. "When he sees a child about to fall into a well, he cannot help a feeling of alarm and commiseration" (Chan, 1963a)—the activation of this unity in humaneness is not the result of reasoning, nor the moral judgment "I ought to sympathize," but a direct response prior to the subject-object cut. Humane substance (ren ti) is originally interconnected; the separation is something added later.

> The highest good is the ultimate standard for making bright one's bright virtue and loving the people. The nature endowed by Heaven is the highest good in its purest state. To be luminous, shining, and not beclouded are manifestations of the highest good. This is the original state of bright virtue or what is called pure knowing. (Wang Yangming, *Inquiry on the Great Learning*; Ivanhoe, 2009)

Innate knowledge is not another clock—not another source of readings. Innate knowledge is "luminous, shining, and not beclouded"—a moral awareness that does not need to complete a theoretical proof of external objects before springing into action. It is not "knowing what," but "knowing what one is doing, while simultaneously knowing whether this 'doing' corresponds to the unity of all things through humaneness." Wang Yangming's last words on his deathbed were: "My heart is full of brightness; what more can I say." (*Complete Works of Wang Yangming*, "Chronological Biography," the eleventh month of the seventh year of the Jiajing reign)[12]—innate knowledge is not an object to be captured by language; it is itself luminosity.

Contrast: Zhu Xi. Zhu Xi's (1130–1200) "investigating things to extend knowledge" provides a structural contrast. In the supplementary commentary to Chapter 5 of the *Commentary on the Great Learning*, Zhu Xi says: "The meaning of the expression 'The perfection of knowledge depends on the investigation of things (ko-wu)' is this: If we wish to extend our knowledge to the utmost, we must investigate the principles of all things we come into contact with, for the intelligent mind of man is certainly formed to know, and there is not a single thing in which its principles do not inhere." (Chan, 1963a) By examining concrete things one by one to accumulate knowledge—"After exerting himself in this way for a long time, he will one day achieve a wide and far-reaching penetration. Then the qualities of all things, whether internal or external, the refined or the coarse, will all be apprehended, and the mind, in its total substance and great functioning, will be perfectly intelligent." (Zhu Xi, *Collected Annotations on the Four Books*, *Commentary on the Great Learning*, supplementary commentary to Chapter 5; Chan, 1963a).

In his youth, Wang Yangming investigated bamboo for seven days[13], fell gravely ill, and discovered that Zhu Xi's path was unworkable. Not because Zhu Xi was "wrong," but because no matter how one investigates things, what one obtains is still the principle of things, not the "unity" between mind and things. Wang Yangming

[12]"My heart is full of brightness; what more can I say." (Ching's rendering) comes from the *Complete Works of Wang Yangming*, "Chronological Biography": on the twenty-ninth day of the eleventh month of the seventh year of the Jiajing reign (January 9, 1529 in the Gregorian calendar), Wang Yangming died aboard a boat at Qinglongpu in Nan'an, Jiangxi, these being his final words. For English renderings of this sentence, see Julia Ching, *To Acquire Wisdom: The Way of Wang Yang-ming* (1976): "My heart is full of brightness; what more can I say."; and JeeLoo Liu, *Neo-Confucianism: Metaphysics, Mind, and Morality* (2018), which, in quoting it, rewords the phrasing as "The mind is totally luminous and bright. What is the need to say anything more?"

[13]Wang Yangming's investigation of bamboo is recorded in *Instructions for Practical Living*, Part III: "People merely say that in the investigation of things we must follow Chu Hsi, but when have they carried it out in practice? I have carried it out earnestly and definitely. In my earlier years my friend Ch'ien and I discussed the idea that to become a sage or a worthy one must investigate all the things in the world. But how can a person have such tremendous energy? I therefore pointed to the bamboos in front of the pavilion and told him to investigate them and see. Day and night Mr. Ch'ien went ahead trying to investigate to the utmost the principles in the bamboos. He exhausted his mind and thoughts and on the third day he was tired out and took sick. At first I said that it was because his energy and strength were insufficient. Therefore I myself went to try to investigate to the utmost. From morning till night, I was unable to find the principles of the bamboos. On the seventh day I also became sick because I thought too hard." (Chan, 1963b)

turned in another direction: not seeking the mapping function outwardly, but directly restoring, within action, the original state of the unity of all things in humaneness. "The extension of innate knowledge" is not "finding a thing called innate knowledge and then following it"—innate knowledge is not outside, does not need to be obtained through investigating things. It is directly manifest in action. "Refining through affairs"[14] is allowing innate knowledge to manifest in real action, not accumulating readings through the comparison of readings.

Contrast: Descartes. Descartes attempted to find certainty within the interior of the mind ("I think, therefore I am"). In Wang Yangming's philosophical thought, certainty lies not in the activity of thinking within the mind, but in human beings' "refining through affairs" and their "dealings" with the world. Descartes found that "there exists a person who is reading the clock," but did not resolve whether "the clock points to the real time." Wang Yangming bypassed this question—in his framework, there is no need to first confirm the accuracy of "knowledge" before acting, because the "knowing" of "the extension of innate knowledge" is not cognition of an external object, but moral intuition and the power of judgment directly manifest in action. **If one borrows the language of Chapter 1, one could say:** In action, one directly contacts the real; the consequences of action may provide new evidence for calibration—when this feedback can form an independent constraint on existing judgments, calibration can proceed within action. One does not calibrate first and then act, but, under these conditions, calibrates within action. **Yet it must be remembered: Wang Yangming's "innate knowledge" is a moral substance; Chapter 1's "calibration" is an epistemological operation. The two are structurally adjacent in their "independence from a pre-existing mapping," but their orientation and foundation differ.**

§3.5 The Common Zone of the Four Nodes

Laozi, the Buddha, Huineng, and Lu Jiuyuan with Wang Yangming—the four nodes are not saying the same thing. Laozi's "non-being" is a diminishing—"the pursuit of the Dao means having less each day"—continuously reducing one's dependence on mappings. (Lynn, 1999) The Buddha's teaching of "non-abiding" in the Diamond Sutra is a recursive dismantling—even "non-abiding" itself is not to be abided in. Huineng's "awakening" is a transformation of the state of existence between delusion and awakening—not acquiring new knowledge, but changing one's relationship to mapping. The Lu-Wang School's "the mind is principle"—from Lu Jiuyuan's proposition to Wang Yangming's "extension of innate knowledge"—is a restoration of the original unity: the separation is something humans added; remove this separation, and there is no need to build a bridge.

They do not provide "solutions to the gap." In their languages, there is not even the word "gap." What they speak of is something else: diminishing, non-abiding, delusion and awakening, unity. **To juxtapose the four teachings here is not to construct a unified "Eastern wisdom" to oppose "Western reason"—that would be a double simplification of both sides. The sole reason for this juxtaposition is: they provide, for the predicament diagnosed in Chapter 1, four different images of an exit, all of which point toward "not relying on more mappings."**

If the reader discerns some relationship between them and the predicament of Chapter 1, this does not mean

[14] "Refining through affairs" is this chapter's summary rendering of Wang Yangming's account of self-cultivation, not a verbatim English phrase from the Lu Cheng record. The direct textual anchor in *Instructions for Practical Living*, Part I, the Lu Cheng record, is: "I said, 'One's feelings seem to be all right when one is quiet. However, when something happens, they become different. Why is it?' The Teacher said, 'This is because one only knows how to cultivate oneself in quietness and does not exert effort to master oneself. One must be trained and polished in the actual affairs of life. Only then can one stand firm and remain calm whether in activity or in tranquillity.'" (Chan, 1963b) The Chinese text additionally contains the sentence "如此，临事便要倾倒," meaning "In this condition, one will falter when confronted with affairs" (author's translation). This sentence is not included in Chan's rendering quoted above.

that these traditions follow from one another by causal derivation or that this book's translation created them. They took shape independently; this chapter uses structural reading to mark comparable relations of adjacency between them and the predicament of Chapter 1. Viewed from these zones, the subject-object estrangement confronted by the mainstream of Western metaphysics is not an ultimate condition beyond reflection. When the human being withdraws from the primordial undivided state of being one with the world and posits themselves as an isolated subject facing a world, the impulse to build bridges emerges. The bridges become ever more sophisticated, but each new bridge reaffirms the existence of the distance. What this chapter examines on this basis is how subject-object division intensifies the mapping predicament, not how every mapping gap can be reduced to a product of a state of existence.

The mainstream of Western metaphysics began building bridges after the distance appeared. If one accepts the structural comparative reading of this chapter, the "direction" of these important nodes of Eastern philosophy can be restated as: not a temporal regression, not abandoning all mappings to return to a primitive state, but marking that the three layers of irreversibility are irreversibility "within the clock dimension," and providing a direction: **while using the clock, do not take the clock as a substitute for time.** The Diamond Sutra says, "You should activate the mind without dwelling on anything"—not dwelling in any mapping, yet still maintaining awareness. Lu Jiuyuan says, "authority resides in me"—the clock is for me to use, rather than for me to be enslaved by it. Wang Yangming says, "refining through affairs"—direct contact in action, though the action itself may still need to use mappings. Huineng says, "Buddhism is in the world; / It is not realized apart from the world"—not leaving the world to find another reality, but maintaining awareness within the world. (Cleary, 1998)[15]

Here, a common limit must be honestly marked: if the "not yet split" or "originally one body" is itself merely a retrospective construction after discretization, then "returning" is, in a strict sense, impossible; if it is an experiential fact independent of conceptualization, then it cannot be fully tested within the framework of the Clock Room. The shared premise of the four schools' schemes—that a certain state of contact/awareness, uncut by mapping, can be reached—cannot be verified or falsified by this chapter using its own framework; this limit comes from the difference in the foundations of the two sets of languages, not from vagueness in wording. The point of the four schools is practical: stop arguing within the conceptual fragments produced by discretization, and return to that awareness itself, before it was split.

The Eastern line has a further node in modern times: the twentieth-century Feng Youlan used logical analysis—what he called "the positive method"—to reconstruct Chinese metaphysics. In Chapter 28 of *A Short History of Chinese Philosophy*, he recalled that, after writing *New Li-hsüeh*, he began to recognize the importance of the negative method, and proposed that philosophy "is that branch of knowledge which, in its development, will ultimately become 'the knowledge that is not knowledge' " (Feng Youlan, 1948: ch. 28). This judgment stands at a mutually recognizable distance from the core insight of the Clock Room. It continues resources from Chinese traditional thought while also belonging to Feng's work of comparing and combining Chinese and Western philosophical methods.

[15] Feng Youlan's judgment on the primary spirit of Chinese philosophy can be cross-referenced with this reading: "So far as the main tenet of its tradition is concerned, if we understand it aright, it cannot be said to be wholly this-worldly, just as, of course, it cannot be said to be wholly other-worldly. It is both of this world and of the other world. Speaking about the Neo-Confucianism of the Sung Dynasty, one philosopher described it this way: 'It is not divorced from daily ordinary activities, yet it goes straight to what antedated Heaven.' " He further points out: "The task of Chinese philosophy is to accomplish a synthesis out of these antitheses" (Feng Youlan, 1948: ch. 1). The phrasing of §3.5 of this chapter—"while using the clock, do not take the clock as a substitute for time"—can be read as one attempt to operationalize this synthesis.

§4 A Modern Convergence

§4.1 Marx: The Inversion Setting Out from Within the Western Tradition

Within the Western tradition itself, a profound turn occurred. Marx (1818–1883) turned Hegel upside down: it is not Spirit that moves; it is embodied, sensuous human beings who labor in the material world. In this chapter's structural reading, Marx reveals, from the side of philosophical critique, how this bridge is built. The following use of Marx follows the same principle as the preceding use of Plato or Laozi: a structural reading within the problem-domain of the "mapping gap," capturing only the recognizable relations between "sensuous existence," "alienation," "practice," and the mapping predicament.

In the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*, Marx proposed the concept of the "sensuous being" (sinnliches Wesen). The human being is not an abstract thinking subject, but an embodied, suffering being in direct causal contact with nature. Marx holds that man's feelings and passions are "not merely anthropological phenomena in the [narrower] sense, but truly ontological affirmations of essential being (of nature)" (Marx, 1844; the Chinese text follows *Collected Works of Marx and Engels*, vol. 1, People's Publishing House, 2009, with "narrower" used to correct that edition's "original" in accordance with the German *engeren*)—feeling itself is the mode of the human being's direct contact with the world, not a low-grade material awaiting processing by thought.

The human being is a "species-being" (Gattungswesen), taking the species as its object not only in theory but also in practice, treating itself as the present, living, universal, and therefore free being. Unlike animals, humans can produce universally and examine themselves in the world they have created.

Marx's "alienation" (Entfremdung) describes the process by which this mode of direct contact becomes compressed and governed. "[T]he object which labour produces—labour's product—confronts it as something alien, as a power independent of the producer. … objectification as loss of the object and object-bondage; appropriation as estrangement, as alienation." (Marx, 1844) Alienated labor reduces free, conscious activity to a mere means for the physical subsistence of the individual. The worker still makes contact with the world as a sensuous being—through body, materials, machines, and the consequences of labor—but the rhythm of labor is increasingly governed by external timekeeping and production metrics—this is the shift from "working in time" (the mode of existence of multi-channel, direct contact with the world as distinguished in Chapter 1, §5) to "working on clocks" (the operational mode of processing only discrete readings), occurring at the most literal level. The human being's mode of direct contact with the world as a sensuous being is compressed into the operation of reading and obeying readings.

In this chapter's structural reading, Marx stands closest to the Clock Room, with Heidegger second. In *The Poverty of Philosophy*, Marx used two metaphors to criticize the bridge-building operation in the history of Western philosophy—the tradition of abstracting the concrete into ideas, gradually stripping away everything concrete until only a logical category remains.

The first: "Is it surprising that, if you let drop little by little all that constitutes the individuality of a house, leaving out first of all the materials of which it is composed, then the form that distinguishes it, you end up with nothing but a body; that, if you leave out of account the limits of this body; you soon have nothing but a space

– that if, finally, you leave out of the account the dimensions of this space, there is absolutely nothing left but pure quantity, the logical category? If we abstract thus from every subject all the alleged accidents, animate or inanimate, men or things, we are right in saying that in the final abstraction, the only substance left is the logical category. Thus the metaphysicians who, in making these abstractions, think they are making analyses, and who, the more they detach themselves from things, imagine themselves to be getting all the nearer to the point of penetrating to their core – these metaphysicians in turn are right in saying that things here below are embroideries of which the logical categories constitute the canvas. This is what distinguishes the philosopher from the Christian. The Christian, in spite of logic, has only one incarnation of the *Logos*; the philosopher has never finished with incarnations. If all that exists, all that lives on land, and under water, can be reduced by abstraction to a logical category – if the whole real world can be drowned thus in a world of abstractions, in the world of logical categories – who need be astonished at it?" (Marx, 1847)

The second: "If the Englishman transforms men into hats, the German transforms hats into ideas. The Englishman is Ricardo, rich banker and distinguished economist; the German is Hegel, simple professor at the University of Berlin." (Marx, 1847)—Ricardo reduced men to the cost of producing hats; Hegel, in turn, reduced the hats to ideas.

§4.2 A Zone of Mutual Recognizability

This section uses the phrasing "a zone of mutual recognizability," the strict meaning of which is given by the introduction of §3 and item (4) of footnote 1; it will not be redefined here.

Marx and the Eastern traditions were not speaking of the same thing. Marx was concerned with material production and class struggle; the Buddha was concerned with suffering and liberation; Laozi was concerned with diminishing in the pursuit of the Dao; Wang Yangming was concerned with the refinement of innate knowledge through affairs. Their points of departure, routes of travel, and the landscapes seen upon arrival all differ.

Yet, setting out from entirely different points of departure, they arrived at a zone of mutual recognizability.

Laozi said, "the pursuit of the Dao means having less each day" (Lynn, 1999)—reducing dependence on mappings. Wang Yangming said, "the extension of innate knowledge"—restoring the unity of all things through humaneness within action. Huineng said, "Originally there's not a single thing"—questioning the reality of dust. Marx said, "sensuous being"—returning to an embodied mode of existence in direct causal contact with nature. These four propositions differ in content and are not interchangeable with one another. But they can be seen simultaneously at a single point: none of them located the way out of the predicament in "building a better mapping system"—the way out was located, in each case, in some transformation of the state of existence of the knower themselves.

The meaning of this "returning" is not the same. Laozi's "returning" is a diminishing. Wang Yangming's "returning" is self-cultivation (gongfu). Huineng's "returning" is a letting go. Marx's "returning" is praxis—through transforming the social relations that alienate the human being, restoring the direct relationship between the human being and the world, and between the human being and their own species-essence. They are not the same operation. Yet they all point toward a common judgment: the problem is not that the mapping is insufficiently good, but that the human being has lost a mode of existence not dominated by any single reading system.[16]

[16]Wang Defeng, approaching from the direction of the philosophy of art, arrived at a mutually recognizable judgment: the funda-

This convergence is not entirely accidental. When a task requires recovering state dimensions discarded by dimension reduction, mapping is necessarily lossy for that task, and the strategy of bridge-building encounters a principled limit; when a task concerns only a defined low-dimensional quantity, however, this does not by itself establish that calibration is ineffective. Continuing to do work within the clock dimension cannot resolve the structural limitation of the clock dimension itself. At this point, **these intellectual efforts attempting to cross beyond the subject-object dichotomy, regardless of their cultural origin, tend, in terms of direction, to arrive at the same zone.** Von Neumann, from the inner practice of the foundations of mathematics, was pushed to a similar position—this further illustrates: this direction does not entirely depend on cultural tradition; it comes, to some degree, from a **deep encounter with the structural predicament that "a system cannot self-certify from within."**

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§5 The Clock Room at the Intersection

The Clock Room sits at the intersection of the two paths.

It uses the formal tools developed by the Western tradition (mapping, fiber, proofs of impossibility) to make precise a difficulty. This difficulty itself is not new—the lines of Eastern philosophy had already touched upon it in another language. But intuition is not proof. Chapter 1 provided the argument: the three layers of irreversibility—of which the third layer, under the usual spatial conditions (a continuous dimension-reducing mapping cannot remain injective across all true states), is a mathematically ineliminable structural limitation, the first layer has a formal argument under boundary conditions, and the second is a mechanism analysis.

At the same time, the state presented in the lines of Eastern philosophy—not bridging the distance, but changing one's relationship to the distance—does not, in a strict formal sense, provide additional probative resources for the argument of Chapter 1, but it does provide a philosophically referable direction for "how to exist after knowing the three layers of irreversibility." The "bookkeeping structure" proposed in Chapter 1 is not an attempt to eliminate the fiber, but to track the three layers differently: for the first layer, it records how much of the mapping is known and the state of calibration; for the second, it records the rate of corrosion and the frequency of calibration; for the third, it only marks the existence of ineliminable uncertainty without quantifying unknown dimensions. Where a metric can be defined for the gap, it sounds the alarm before that gap accumulates to a dangerous degree. This operational way out and the judgment of the *Tao Te Ching* that "therefore this is how what is there provides benefit and how what is not there provides functionality" occupy a zone of mutual recognizability—though one is an engineering discipline, the other a philosophical judgment, their points of departure and modes of expression are entirely different.

MacKenzie (2009), developing Callon's (2005) concept of agencement, provides a precise anchor for this: the actor is not an atomized individual, but a composite assembled from human bodies, tools, algorithms, and procedures. The person in the Clock Room is precisely such an assemblage: a human body plus N clocks plus the procedure of reading clocks plus the default understanding of "accuracy." The proposition of this book

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mental character of traditional aesthetics (and of the broader Western metaphysical tradition) is an "epistemological orientation"—"a ready-made rational subject confronting an equally ready-made sensuous object"; while the "existential orientation" opened by Marx and Heidegger returns to the sensuous activity of the human being—"not 'logically knowing' external objects out of reason, but 'experiencing' the 'way of being' of beings out of existence" (Wang Defeng, 2005/2015: Introduction, §§4–5; author's translation). This chapter's treatment of the two paths of the "mapping predicament" is indebted to this distinction.

does not stop at describing this assemblage—but pursues: under what conditions can an actor assembled by clocks perform a self-audit of their own capacity to be a temporal existent? When the assemblage interrogates its own constitution—"What am I assembled from? Has this assemblage already replaced what I originally possessed?"—this very interrogation makes the conditions of formation of the actor's own agency itself an object of reflection. Huineng's "it is your mind that moves" is structurally adjacent to this interrogation—not asking "which clock is accurate," but asking "why am I reading clocks?" An even earlier formulation of this line is what Huineng gave in the *Platform Sutra*: **"Each of you must liberate yourselves through your own essential nature; that is called true liberation"** (Cleary, 1998): subjectivity is not installing the "I" as an epistemic subject confronting objects, but letting inherent nature manifest itself, not being enslaved by external things.[17] Lu Jiuyuan's "authority resides in me" and Wang Yangming's "extension of innate knowledge" are continuations of this line on the Confucian side, transformations of the state of existence triggered by the same interrogation.

The way out is not building better clocks, but **restoring the capacity to work in time**—civilization cannot do without clocks. But clocks exist for the sake of time; civilization exists for the sake of the human being. The way out is, while using the clock, maintaining direct contact with time as existence, and knowing the difference between these two modes of doing work. Wang Yangming would say: refine through affairs; restore the unity of all things through humaneness within action. Von Neumann would say: the Baroque development of a discipline cannot become detached from experience.

These formulations are not the same sentence. But they point toward a common judgment:

This is not time; this is a clock. Know this, and then continue to use the clock—but do not forget the difference between the clock and time.

The end of Chapter 1 points toward a bookkeeping structure—an operationalized discipline (whose full framework, the Macro-Cognitive Accounting Framework (MCAF), will be given in Chapter 3). The end of this chapter further points toward "knowing this is a clock, but continuing to use it, not forgetting the cognitive debt"—an ontological awakening. "Cognitive debt" is used here in the sense defined in Chapter 3: an ordinal residual sedimented by the collision of two heterogeneous structures, projective load and defensive capacity. It is not an unsettled difference automatically generated whenever a reading is accepted in place of direct experience; such substitution must be registered and assessed within a specific projection-defense relation. Its full definition and accounting scheme (the Macro-Cognitive Accounting Framework, MCAF) are given in Chapter 3. The bookkeeping structure is the practice; "not forgetting the cognitive debt" is the knowledge. **The endings of the two chapters thus constitute a dialogue: Chapter 1 provides an operational entry point; Chapter 2 marks the boundary of this entry point. Between the two, there is no Hegelian "unity" (the synthesis that bridges all distance through dialectical movement, as discussed in §2.4); there is only a sustained, mutually corrective tension.**

[17] *Platform Sutra*, "Repentance" chapter: "Good friends, the beings in the mind … states of mind like this are all beings. Each of you must liberate yourselves through your own essential nature; that is called true liberation." (Cleary, 1998) The "Personal History" chapter records that when Huineng was ferried across the river, he answered Hongren: "I have had the honor to inherit the dharma from you. Since I am now enlightened, it is only right for me to cross the sea of birth and death myself by realizing my own essence of mind." (Price & Wong, 1969) Wang Defeng positions this Chan Buddhist proposition as a clear articulation of the principle of subjectivity on the side of Chinese philosophy, forming a dual-track contrast with Descartes' modern Western principle of subjectivity, "I think, therefore I am" (lecture on "The Contemporary Significance of Yangming's School of Mind").

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